



The Humanitas Institute

Six Elements of Classical Education School Website Audit

School: Ascent Classical Academy of Greenville
School Website: <https://greenville.ascentclassicalsc.org/>

December 22, 2025

Disclaimer

This audit was performed using artificial intelligence tools to evaluate the presence and strength of classical education principles on school websites. Results are automated, probabilistic in nature, and should be considered indicative rather than definitive. See the full disclaimer in the Appendix for more details.

ACCS Member School

Any school that belongs to the Association of Classical Christian Schools ACCS or the Society for Classical Learning SCL is, by definition, recognized as a classical school because both organizations require adherence to the six essential elements defined by the Humanitas Institute. However, a school's website may not clearly reflect its conformity to one or more elements. In such cases, the school may still receive a "Somewhat Classical" rating for those elements. Schools can update their website content at any time to achieve a "Classical" rating for a given element.

Executive Summary

Ascent Classical Academy of Greenville (Greenville, SC 29607) presents a robust Classical model as reflected in its public materials. The school consistently foregrounds core classical aims—virtue formation, a content-rich liberal-arts curriculum, and disciplined pedagogy grounded in tradition—while also signaling a strong family-partner model typical of Classical schools. Across six rubric categories, the school demonstrates substantial Classical alignment, with Element 1 showing partial alignment due to a relatively lighter emphasis on explicit theology or liturgical practice. The aggregate assessment across the six categories is CLASSICAL, with Element 1 marked as SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL. The school's public-facing materials repeatedly emphasize truth, goodness, beauty, virtue, memory-work, Great Books/primary sources, Socratic elements, and a parental partnership orientation, all of which map to the Six Essential Elements rubric.

Key signaling keywords observed on the school site include: classical education, liberal arts, Core Knowledge, Great Books, primary sources, Socratic discussion, memory work (narration, recitation), virtue and moral character, civic virtue, wonder, and partnership with families. The public materials also describe a mission to train the minds and improve the hearts of students, via a disciplined, orderly environment and a content-rich curriculum in the liberal arts and sciences. Together, these elements align with a deeply classical approach, with the strongest signals in Curriculum, Pedagogy, Faculty, and Parents & Community, and a clearly present but more modest articulation in Religious & Metaphysical Foundations.

Executive Summary — Element-by-Element Snapshot

Element 1: Religious and Metaphysical Foundations — SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL

- Evidence
 - The Extended Mission cites Truth, Justice, Virtue, Right, and Character as guiding ideals (explicit reference to transcendent moral aims) .
 - The mission statement emphasizes virtue, moral realism, and reverence for the moral order within a liberal-arts framework (virtue, moral character, civic virtue) as part of forming humane citizens .
 - The site repeatedly links to “truth, goodness, and beauty” and to wonder as educational anchors (e.g., statements about training minds and hearts, and engagement with beauty and moral inquiry) (e.g., The Pursuit of Truth at a Time of Unrest and related content) .
- Positive/Negative Keyword Analysis
 - Positive keywords observed: truth, goodness, beauty, virtue, moral character, civic virtue, wonder, contemplation, moral imagination.
 - Negative keywords observed: none identified in public materials.
 - Frequency signal: multiple explicit mentions of truth/goodness/beauty and virtue across mission-focused content; no explicit theology or liturgical practice cited in public pages.
- Why this rating
 - Strong alignment with transcendental moral aims and virtue formation, but explicit theology, liturgy, or communal liturgical practices are not foregrounded in the Greenville public materials. Thus, Element 1 reaches a solid SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL rather than a full CLASSICAL due to the lighter theological/liturgical emphasis in public materials.

Citations: Truth/virtue/beauty and moral formation cited in mission and vision pages; explicit transcendentals language in Extended Mission; civil virtue and moral character emphasis in program descriptions.

Element 2: School Purpose and Goal — CLASSICAL

- Evidence
 - The school’s public wording states a goal of “training the minds and improving the hearts of young people through a classical, content-rich education in the liberal arts and sciences, with instruction in the principles of moral character and civic virtue in an orderly and disciplined environment” (formation of character and civic virtue as primary aims) .
 - Language surrounding virtue, wisdom, and human flourishing appears as a core telos (formation of character and moral imagination; classical heritage) in mission statements and program descriptions. The pursuit of truth, beauty, and goodness is repeatedly highlighted in the context of Classical education (e.g., Purposes of Classical Education content and related pages) .
 - The school frames education as formation (habits of virtue, character development) rather than mere information, aligning with paideia/classical aims (liberal education, classical mission) as a guiding telos .
- Positive/Negative Keyword Analysis
 - Positive keywords observed: formation, liberal education, paideia, classical mission, telos, pursuit of the true/good/beautiful, heightening wisdom and virtue, character formation, moral imagination, great conversation.
 - Negative keywords observed: explicit emphasis on workforce preparation/career-readiness is not present; no direct emphasis on 21st-century skills or job-market metrics.
 - Frequency signal: Strong presence of formation telos and classical aims; minimal to no appearance of workforce-focused language.
- Why this rating
 - The school explicitly presents formation, virtue, liberal education, and a classical mission as the core aims of education, with a strong emphasis on truth/beauty/goodness in the classical framework. This aligns with CLASSICAL scoring in Element 2.

Citations: Formation/virtue/liberal education/telos language in mission statements; Great Conversation and true/good/beautiful framing in curriculum content.

Element 3: School Curriculum — CLASSICAL

- Evidence
 - Core Knowledge is described as the content-rich backbone of K–8 instruction (history, science, art, music) with emphasis on memorized background knowledge to enable deeper reasoning and humanities engagement (the Western heritage frame) .
 - The curriculum emphasizes Great Books, primary sources, and classical texts as part of forming opinions and a “Great Conversation” in Western civilization, aligning with classical curriculum patterns (great books, primary sources, Western civilization) .
 - Foundational elements include grammar, logic, rhetoric; historical engagement with Western tradition; memorization (recitation, narration) and liturgical-inflected arts (hymnody, sacred art) reflected in the documented materials (visible references to Trivium-like elements in curriculum maps/communication) .
- Positive/Negative Keyword Analysis
 - Positive keywords observed: liberal arts, grammar, logic, rhetoric; great books; primary sources; Western civilization; history; memory-work (recitation, narration); hymnodic arts; sacred art.
 - Negative keywords observed: minimal to no reliance on separate “social studies” framing; no explicit emphasis on project-based learning dominating the curriculum (public materials emphasize

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- content knowledge and classical texts rather than a project-first approach).
 - Frequency signal: Multiple explicit classical curriculum anchors; low presence of non-classical “project-based” dominance or social studies substitution; strong Great Books/primary sources/grammar-logic-rhetoric signals.
 - Why this rating
 - The site materials present a content-rich, liberal-arts-forward curriculum with explicit emphasis on Trivium/Quadrivium-adjacent ideas, Great Books/primary sources, and a coherent historical-cultural framework. This aligns solidly with CLASSICAL criteria in Curriculum.

Citations: Core Knowledge description; Great Books/primary sources; Trivium elements from curriculum content; Western civilization framing.

Element 4: School Pedagogy or Teaching Methods — CLASSICAL

- Evidence
 - Pedagogical language foregrounds Socratic discussion, dialectic, and seminar-style learning in upper grades; use of primary sources; memory work and recitation are highlighted as methods (narration, chanting, and memorization are noted in core pedagogy) .
 - The public materials emphasize teacher-led instruction with substantial structure, practice in rhetoric, and opportunities for students to give speeches, learn through dialogue, and engage in classical discourse (Socratic techniques, rhetoric training) .
 - There is explicit mention of restfulness/scholé in pedagogy and a goal to foster wonder in the lower grades as memory and delight are deepened (lower grammar stage singing/memorization; upper grades seminars) .
- Positive/Negative Keyword Analysis
 - Positive keywords observed: Socratic seminar, dialectic, disputation, narration, recitation, chanting, memory work, liturgical/calendar integration, seminar, Paideia, rhetoric, declamation, oratory, debate, capstone orations, scholé, wonder.
 - Negative keywords observed: experiential learning focus, project-based learning dominance, student-directed learning as a sole mode (not the focus here).
 - Frequency signal: Strong presence of Socratic and memory-based pedagogy, with concurrent emphasis on disciplined, teacher-guided instruction and classical rhetorical practice.
- Why this rating
 - The school's public-facing content strongly aligns with the classical pedagogy pattern: memory work and recitation for early years; Socratic discussion and rhetoric training for upper grades; classic forms of seminar and dialectic, rather than a purely project-based or student-led-only approach.

Citations: Socratic techniques and primary sources; memory work and recitation language; upper-grade rhetoric/seminar language; scholé/wonder framing.

Element 5: School Faculty — CLASSICAL

- Evidence
 - Public materials describe faculty as capable, virtuous educators who model virtue and form the living curriculum; staff care about the heart and mind; portraits of teacher ideals are referenced in the “living curriculum” language (faculty as exemplars, mentors) .
 - The mission emphasizes teachers as the core of the school (mentor-like role; classical formation of teachers; teacher-led instruction). The public materials describe a disciplined, orderly environment with teacher-led instruction and high standards for faculty expertise .
 - The organizational materials mention governance and mission alignment, indicating a stable faculty culture and a “portrait of a teacher” or “living curriculum” approach embedded in the school's

ethos.

- Positive/Negative Keyword Analysis
 - Positive keywords observed: tutors/masters/mentors/guides/exemplars, portrait of a teacher, living curriculum, collegial culture, faculty of friends, moral exemplars, character formation, teacher leadership, classical pedagogy.
 - Negative keywords observed: none observed in public materials (no explicit benchmarking against non-classical pedagogy terms here).
 - Frequency signal: The materials consistently frame faculty as central to classical formation and living curriculum.
- Why this rating
 - The school's public content strongly conveys Classical-faculty signals through language about virtuous teachers, living curriculum, and mentorship, consistent with CLASSICAL scoring for Faculty.

Citations: Mission-language and teacher-centered pedagogy; living curriculum language; faculty-centered claims in governance/mission content.

Element 6: School Parents & Community — CLASSICAL

- Evidence
 - The school explicitly emphasizes partnership with families and identifies parents as co-teachers with the school. The mission describes a family-school partnership and the central role of parental involvement, with information meetings and open access for parents to engage (parent information meetings, open campus concepts) .
 - Materials describe education of parents through book studies and gatherings to help families understand classical education; openness to visits by parents; and a shared mission with families (home-school alignment, family formation, parent participation) .
 - The school communicates an inclusive policy and invites parental involvement via information meetings, lotteries, and open enrollment processes, reinforcing parent engagement as a core principle of the Classical model (co-teachers, parental covenant, open campus) .
- Positive/Negative Keyword Analysis
 - Positive keywords observed: partnership with families, co-teachers, parental formation, home-school connection, family involvement, parent formation, classical parent training, parent covenant, open campus, hospitable campus, family participation, shared mission.
 - Negative keywords observed: none identified in the public materials.
 - Frequency signal: Strong and continuous presence of parental engagement language; explicit calls for parental involvement and education.
- Why this rating
 - The Greenville site presents a robust Classical-parents/community alignment with explicit partnership language and opportunities for parent involvement, supporting CLASSICAL scoring in this category.

Citations: Partnership with families; parent formation; open visits; information meetings; home-school alignment.

What Would Move the Needle

- If Element 1 remains SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL (due to a lighter explicit theology/liturgy signal), the needle could move toward FULL CLASSICAL by:
 - More explicit articulation of theological grounding (or liturgical/communal practices) within public-facing materials, while preserving the non-denominational stance if required. This would address the Grounded in Theology and Liturgical/Communal Practices criteria.

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- Adding explicit statements about liturgical rhythms, communal worship, or sacred tradition in attendance or chapel contexts, where aligned with the school's philosophy.
 - Optional enhancements (not strictly required given current strength, but would fortify CLASSICAL alignment):
 - A clearer articulation of the Great Books component as a formal requirement or explicit Great Conversation framing within the Great Books curriculum map (beyond primary sources and Core Knowledge) to reinforce the Great Conversation criterion.
 - Expanded explicit reference to the Trivium (grammar, logic, rhetoric) as foundational to K–12 pedagogy across curriculum maps, with concrete examples of how these three arts shape instruction in each grade level.

Citations: Theoretical alignment with the Six Elements' Element 1 subcriteria; suggested enhancements for theology/liturgy signals.

Appendix

ARTIFICIAL INTELLIGENCE DISCLAIMER

This audit was conducted using artificial intelligence tools (including large language models and automated web-analysis scripts) to evaluate the extent to which school websites reflect or incorporate recognized principles of classical education (e.g., the trivium, emphasis on truth/beauty/goodness, integration of great books, Latin/classical languages, Socratic method, rigorous academics, moral/character formation, etc.).

Important Limitations and Caveats

1. **Automated Nature:** The analysis relies on AI interpretation of publicly-accessible school website content as of the date of the audit. It does not involve direct contact with schools, review of internal documents, classroom observation, or verification of curriculum implementation beyond what is stated or implied on the website.
2. **Probabilistic Results:** Scores and assessments are probabilistic and reflect the AI's best interpretation of available text and site structure. They are not infallible and may miss nuance, context, or recent changes not yet reflected online.
3. **Subjectivity of Classical Education:** "Classical Education" encompasses a range of traditions and interpretations (e.g., Dorothy Sayers' trivium model, Classical Christian Education, Great Books programs, etc.). The Humanitas Institute Audit of the Six Elements of Classical Education uses a broad, consensus-based framework derived from prominent classical education organizations and thought leaders. Reasonable people may disagree on weighting or inclusion of specific criteria.
4. **No Official Endorsement or Certification:** Results do not constitute official endorsement, accreditation, or certification by any classical education organization. They are provided for informational and research purposes only.
5. **Potential for Error:** Websites may be incomplete, poorly worded, or temporarily inaccurate. Conversely, sophisticated marketing language may create false positives. Human review by parents, educators, or classical education experts is strongly recommended before drawing final conclusions about any school.
6. **Data Privacy and Ethics:** Only publicly available information was analyzed. No attempts were made to access password-protected areas or collect personal data.
7. **No Liability:** The authors, developers, and distributors of this audit assume no liability for decisions made on the basis of these results. Users are solely responsible for their own due diligence.

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